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IMPLICATIONS FOR THE ROHINGYAS (2008–2015)

As noted in the previous chapter, the 2008 Constitution actually strengthened the 1982 Constitution's denial of citizenship to the Rohingyas. Moreover, after 1988 the NLD formed a close alliance with the regional ethnic Rakhine parties. Even in the 1990 elections, these parties were arguing for the expulsion of the Rohingyas from the north of the province.[1] Increasingly, the local Rakhine population has backed these ethnically-based regional parties[2] rather than those that operate at a national level, and this has given politics within the state a set of dynamics different to the rest of the country. With one major community (the Rohingyas) effectively disbarred from the electoral process, the stage is left clear for Rakhine extremists.[3]

The Arakan National Party (ANP) was formed in 2013 from a merger of the Rakhine Nationalities Development Party (RNDP) and the Arakan League for Democracy. By 2015 this alliance had broken apart due to the ambitions of senior politicians, and the RNDP is once more a separate party (although the bulk of the membership stayed in the ANP). However, regardless of the label they campaign under, these politicians have been heavily implicated in the 2012 and subsequent massacres and persecution of Rohingyas.[4]

Politics and administration in Rakhine

Geographically, Rakhine occupies the same area as Arakan did before the British conquest in 1826.[5] In ethnic violence in 1942, the previously mixed population of Rohingyas and Rakhine became separated. The bulk of the Rohingyas now live in the northern districts (Maungdaw, Buthidaung and